

INDIAN COMPANIES IN THE RACE

Several Indian pharma companies are in the race for weight-loss drugs, recognising the growing demand for obesity management

ZYDUS LIFESCIENCES

Developing Lupaglutide, a GLP-1 receptor agonist, for both diabetes and weight management, with trials underway

LUPIN

Expanding its pipeline to include obesity-related treatments



SUN PHARMACEUTICAL INDUSTRIES

- **Candidate:** GL0034
- **Status:** Phase 1 studies



DR. REDDY'S LABORATORIES

- **Candidate:** Semaglutide (undergoing bioequivalence study)
- **Status:** Bioequivalence study



ROCHE

Agreed to acquire obesity drug developer Carmot Therapeutics for \$2.7 billion, challenging market leaders Novo Nordisk and Eli Lilly



duce tirzepatide for Type 2 diabetes and weight loss here under its Mounjaro brand this year. It has already got approval from the Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation (CDSCO). In December 2024, the Subject Expert Committee (SEC) recommended granting permission for the import and marketing of the tirzepatide Multi Dose Pen. According to SEC minutes, Eli Lilly must submit its Phase IV trial protocol to CDSCO within three months of approval. Meanwhile, Novo Nordisk's entry is expected in 2026.

Vineet Gupta, Associate Vice President and MD of Eli Lilly (India), says the country remains an important market for Lilly. "We are committed to accelerating the process of bringing our innovative products to the country. We aim to launch tirzepatide in India in 2025 after obtaining all necessary regulatory approvals," he says.

In June 2024, the SEC recommended approving tirzepatide for import and marketing. This applies to six doses in single-dose prefilled pens and vials, subject to the condition that Phase IV clinical trials are conducted and quality and manufacturing requirements are met.

Tirzepatide has already been approved for weight

management and as an adjunct to diet and exercise for Type 2 diabetes in the US and the European Union.

The Big Fat Numbers

IQVIA, a contract research firm, says in its Global Use of Medicines 2023 report that the top therapeutic areas seen driving pharmaceutical spending globally by 2026 are oncology, immunology, diabetes, and cardiovascular and respiratory, in that order. But while obesity is ranked a lowly 19 by absolute spending, only oncology and obesity have a five-year compound annual growth rate or CAGR (2023-2027) in double digits. Oncology is 13-16% and obesity is 13-16%. The others are in low single digits.

Obesity and diabetes have become significant public health challenges in India. The World Health Organization (WHO) says nearly 40% of Indian adults are overweight or obese. (You are overweight if your BMI is greater than or equal to 25 and obese if your BMI is greater than or equal to 30.)

The National Family Health Survey V, done from 2019-21, found that 22.9% of men were overweight against 18.9% in NFHS-IV (2015-16), an increase of four percentage points.